

clouds had assembled ominously across the sky, while the floodlit Barsapara stadium flickered against a fast-greying horizon.

Soon, a thunderstorm descended, briefly threatening to drown the game. But the rain relented in less than an hour, leaving the Diary to ponder his plans.

The Diary had not bothered to bring an umbrella, as summer had already set in. There was also the concern about the stadium's narrow approach roads flooding. And, of course, the prospect of figuring out how to write a 350-word report if the match was called off due to rain.

And thus, the Diary headed to the ground, only after deciding to ditch his brand-new sneakers for slippers, fearing post-rain mud and slush — a smart decision in hindsight.

Eventually, the game happened, albeit a bit late. The 11-over shootout proved to be a slam-bang affair, with Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi setting up the Royals' win with a lightning opening stand. Enough meat for the report and the post-match features, thankfully for the Diary.

Pranay Rajiv



Backroom boom: An optional session, but not a quiet one — Mumbai Indians' backroom presence almost outnumbers the players in the nets. VIJAY SONEJI

Support surge

Gone are the days when IPL franchises travelled with skeletal support staff. Over the past few years, team backrooms have expanded to such an extent that they now resemble full-fledged entourages rather than lean, high-performance units.

At times, particularly during optional training sessions, the imbalance is striking — support staff outnumbering players on the field. One such instance unfolded at the Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad, where Mumbai Indians geared up for a must-win clash against Gujarat Titans. Only three players — Rohit Sharma, Hardik Pandya and Tilak Varma — turned up for the optional session. In contrast, the support staff overseeing proceedings was nearly twice that number, creating an unusual visual of a heavily staffed but sparsely attended practice.

A similar pattern emerged during one of Kolkata Knight Riders' rain-interrupted training sessions, underlining that this is not an isolated case but part of a broader shift in the league's ecosystem.

Franchises, it appears, are leaving little to chance. As one team official explained, the modern approach is rooted in specialisation and microscopic scrutiny of every department. "These days, teams want to scrutinise every department minutely, which is why the number of coaches and support staff has increased. Earlier, there would be one batting coach and one bowling coach. Now, teams employ multiple specialists — a fast-bowling coach, a spin-bowling coach, and several assistant coaches," he said.

The logic is straightforward: marginal gains can make a decisive difference in a tournament as competitive as the IPL. And, as he said, if more teams are following this model, it suggests tangible returns.

Shayan Acharya